

THE CREW

PLAYER'S HANDBOOK

Every rule the game plays by, every number on every screen, and where to find all of it.

We are the criminals. A crew of five, thousands of jobs, and a border in front of every one of them.

Nothing in this handbook is invented. Every figure in it is read out of the game itself.

FOR THE COMMANDER

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WHAT THIS IS

1

CHAPTER 1 · THE GAME IN FOUR MINUTES

1.1 The game

You are the commander of a criminal crew. You are not the police, and there is nobody above you. Clients post work on a board — by country, by kind, with a fee on it — and you decide which of that work your crew takes, who goes on it, and what happens when it goes wrong in the middle.

A turn is a week. Taking a job spends one to three of them, casing a job spends one, laying low spends one. Every week the payroll comes out of your float whether anybody worked or not, the heat falls a little, and the world does something you did not ask it to.

A crew of five, and thousands of jobs. That is the shape of it. Everybody for hire carries five attributes, a trade, a passport, a record, a price and a secret, and the difference between a good crew and a bad one is not their numbers — it is whether their numbers match the room you are sending them into.

Most of them work the sixteen ordinary trades. The rest are specialists — pilots, divers, tunnellers, handlers — and nothing on the board wants one until your name opens the seventh place. See the operations.

1.2 The goal

Build the name. Everything in the game is downstream of your **ranking**: what clients post to you, what they pay, who will sign with you, whether the crew stays loyal, and how hard the police look.

At ranking 420 the board has nothing left to offer you but the last score — three operations, in order, against the Committee. They are the room where the names are kept. Nobody robs them. Finish all three and the game is over, and you won it.

The last score does not appear until four things are true at once:

- A name at the top of the board — ranking 420.
- A career behind you — 55 jobs run.
- A crew, not a pair — 5 people who can actually get in the door.
- A war chest — \$5M on hand. Nobody funds this one.

The Dashboard keeps that list ticked off as it arrives, under **The operation**. There is always a next thing to be working towards, and it is never a mystery what it is.

1.3 **How you lose**

Nobody on the books, and not enough money to hire the cheapest file still available. That is the whole condition. You do not lose by being arrested — you lose by being unable to start again.

The ways people leave the books: they are hurt, they are held, they walk out over the money, they are poached by another crew, they take a cut of a score and vanish, you cut them loose, or they are killed. Every one of those leaves somebody outside your operation who knows things about it, which is its own problem — see loose ends.

1.4 **The three rules the game plays by**

Everything has a cause and a consequence. No number on any screen appeared because it looked right. If a job says you are +9 on the night, there is a line in the factor list saying which week of casing bought it.

The odds are written on the option before you take it. Every twist option, every way of dealing with a loose end, every recruitment snag states its own percentage and its own cost. You are never asked to guess at a hidden number, only to decide whether you can afford the bad half.

Nothing is graded that you did not choose. The game does not invent a verdict. If it cannot know something, it says so rather than filling it in.

2.1 The top bar

Pinned to the top of every screen, and it never scrolls away.

- **The name** — your alias, and the ranking it currently carries.
- **Money** — the float. Fees, cuts, upkeep, retainers, bribes and casing all come out of this one number.
- **Heat** — how hard the world is looking, 0 to 120, drawn as a bar. See Heat and the law.
- **Week** — the clock. Everything in the game is measured in weeks.

2.2 The four tabs

Also pinned. Keys 1 2 3 4 jump straight to them.

TAB	WHAT IS ON IT
Crew	Who is on the books: their cards, attributes, trade, loyalty, cut, upkeep, temperament, limits and what they have been through. Retainers and the safe house are reached from here too, and so is founding a second crew.
Jobs	The board. Every posting open this week, its country, its fee, what it wants, and — once you open one — the job file: who can go, who cannot and why, the odds, the split, and the button that starts it.
Roster	Everybody for hire, filtered — every trade, including the fourteen an operation asks for. This is where hiring happens.
Dashboard	Six folded sections: the operation, the competition and the law, standing arrangements, the record, job recaps, and the case log. One opens at a time; opening one shuts the last.

2.3 The office

Esc, or the ≡ button at the top right, on any screen. It pauses the game and opens the desk: sound, music, brightness, the controls book, your own file, the file cabinet, and the door out.

The i button beside it explains whatever is on screen, and can run the tutorial again — the whole thing, a short reminder, or any single card.

On a screen longer than the window an ↑ appears at the bottom right and takes you back to the top of it. It is not there until there is something above you, and it goes away while anything is waiting to be answered.

2.4 If you are looking for something

YOU WANT	IT IS HERE
A crew member's loyalty	Crew → their card. Also on their full file, opened from the card.
Why somebody cannot go on a job	Jobs → open the posting → Who goes . Every name has a ✓ or a ✗ and the ✗ says why.
How many people the job needs	Jobs → open the posting → Crew needed , at the top of the file.
What you actually keep	Jobs → open the posting → The split . It subtracts the wages as well as the cuts.
Why a job failed	The report itself → WHAT WENT WRONG , which only appears on a botched or blown night, and says what to do differently.
Why a client will not deal with you	Jobs → the notice above the postings. It names the job, the city, the week and the verdict; click it for the whole account. See grudges and revenge.
How to change somebody's trade	Crew → their card → Teach a trade . See a new craft.

YOU WANT

IT IS HERE

Why two of my crew are arguing	They do the same job. See two of the same trade.
The way out of a job file	← Back to job postings , pinned under the tabs — it stays there however far down the file you are.
An old report	Dashboard → Job recaps . Open any one for the whole thing again.
The detective's file	Dashboard → The competition and the law .
Retainers, the safe house, buying off a desk	Dashboard → Standing arrangements .
What the crew has done, and the marks left to take	Dashboard → The record .
The week-by-week log	Dashboard → Case log , filterable by week.
What the last score is still waiting for	Dashboard → The operation .
Small work for one person	Jobs → Quick Money - High Risk , under the postings. See quick money.
Your own file	The office → Your file .
This handbook	The title screen, the office's bookshelf, the controls book, or the footer of any screen.
A copy of your save you can keep	The office → The file cabinet . Writes the game out as one long code and reads one back in.

3.1 Opening a dossier

The title screen is the game's front door: the name, five faces under it, and a way into this handbook. The faces are drawn out of the same face builder every operative on the roster uses, so what you are looking at is a crew — five of the people you are about to go and find.

New game goes to the **WHO ARE YOU?** screen. You choose:

- **Alias** — type one, or press **v** **RANDOM**, which draws a name from the naming pool of the nationality you have picked. A Nigerian commander gets a Nigerian name.
- **Appearance** — a face, drawn in ink. **v** **RANDOM** here too.
- **Sex** — male or female.
- **Nationality** — which passport you carry, which decides which borders are a problem for *you*.
- **Trade** — what you personally are. You count as that trade on every job, exactly as a hired member would.
- **Attributes** — points to spend across the five.

You start with \$150K and four soldiers' places to fill.

3.2 **Command**

You have one number nobody else has: **command**. It starts at 5 and is added to the reckoning of every job you personally go on, on top of everything your attributes and trade are worth.

Recruits who are commander types are worth having and awkward to keep. On a job you are on, each one is -3 — they take orders badly. On a job you cannot get into, the best of them stands in and is worth their command -2, minimum 1. With nobody able to lead, the job is -10 before anybody has done anything.

3.3 **You are always the commander**

There is no mechanism in the game for handing the operation to somebody else. A stand-in leader runs one night and hands it straight back. Every screen addresses you as the person who decides.

THE PEOPLE

CHAPTER 4 · EVERYTHING ON A CREW MEMBER'S FILE

4.1 The five attributes

Every file has five, roughly 20 to 100, and they are the base of everything. A job leans on some of them and ignores the rest — see the twelve kinds of job, and the eight an operation uses.

ATTRIBUTE	WHAT IT IS FOR	WHOSE ATTRIBUTE IT IS
MUS Muscle	Carrying, forcing, holding a door, going up the outside of a building or coming up under it.	<i>The Enforcer's, the Climber's and the Tunneller's.</i>
BRN Brains	Planning, numbers, locks, reading a room's paperwork, and knowing where the kit is before anybody asks.	<i>The Safecracker's, the Forger's, the Lookout's, the Launderer's, the Medic's, the Analyst's and the Quartermaster's.</i>
TCH Tech	Networks, cameras, charges, circuits — anything on the air or under the water that has to be made to behave.	<i>The Hacker's, the Demolitions's, the Drone specialist's, the Chemist's, the Electrician's and the Signals's.</i>
CHM Charm	Talking your way in, selling a lie, running the person on the inside, being the name in the room.	<i>The Grifter's, the Fixer's, the Pickpocket's, the Face's, the Linguist's and the Handler's.</i>
NRV Nerve	Holding still when it goes wrong. Driving it, flying it, sailing it, diving it, or walking in as though invited.	<i>The Wheelman's, the Infiltrator's, the Overwatch's, the Cleaner's, the Smuggler's, the Pilot's, the Skipper's and the Diver's.</i>

The ceiling is 105. Attributes grow slowly from work, and the growth lands on the attributes the job actually leaned on.

4.2 The sixteen trades

A trade is what somebody is. It is not a bonus you can buy — it decides which jobs want them, what knowledge they arrive with, where they stand on the plan, and which options open up when a night goes sideways.

A member whose trade the client asked for is worth +14 on the reckoning, on top of their attributes. Several of the trades also unlock answers nothing else can give you: a Forger gets people across a border they would be turned back from, a Cleaner is the only person who can make a problem an accident, an Enforcer is the only one who can have a conversation, and a Fixer can arrange for somebody to be somewhere else for a long time.

TRADE	LEANS ON	COMES WITH	WHAT THEY DO	ON THE MAP
Safecracker	BRN	Finance	Opens what was meant to stay shut.	the room
Hacker	TCH	Networks	Breaks networks, cameras, cold wallets.	the post
Wheelman	NRV	Logistics	Gets everyone out before the sirens.	the car
Grifter	CHM	Finance	Sells you a lie you want to buy.	the way in
Forger	BRN	Law	Papers, passports, provenance. Gets the crew through borders.	the way in
Enforcer	MUS	Weapons	Makes the problem reconsider.	the room
Fixer	CHM	Politics	Knows a guy for the guy you need.	the post
Infiltrator	NRV	Law	Walks in like the building was expecting it.	the way in
Demolitions	TCH	Weapons	Doors, walls, and distractions.	the room
Pickpocket	CHM	Art	Your watch is already gone.	the way in

TRADE	LEANS ON	COMES WITH	WHAT THEY DO	ON THE MAP
Lookout	BRN	Logistics	Sees the tail three blocks back.	the post
Launderer	BRN	Finance	Turns hot money quiet.	the post
Overwatch	NRV	Weapons	One angle, total control.	the post
Cleaner	NRV	Medicine	No trace, no story, no you.	the car
Face	CHM	Politics	The name in the room, the smile on the deal.	the way in
Smuggler	NRV	Maritime	Moves cargo across any line on a map.	the car

4.3 The fourteen specialists

Fourteen more trades exist, and they are not simply rarer versions of the sixteen — they are the trades that an operation asks for, and ordinary work on the board never does. They are the minority of the roster, so they are something you go looking for rather than something you come across.

They are on the roster from the first week and you may hire one whenever you like. There is no reason to. A Diver on a warehouse job is a stranger with a bottle of air: their trade is never the trade the client named, so they are worth their attributes and nothing more, and they cost \$9K more to sign than somebody who is. Until the seventh place opens they are money spent on a room you cannot yet get into.

TRADE	LEANS ON	COMES WITH	WHAT THEY DO	ON THE MAP
Drone specialist	TCH	Aviation	Eyes, ears and hands where nobody can stand.	the post
Pilot	NRV	Aviation	Anything with wings, off any strip, at night, unfiled.	the car
Skipper	NRV	Maritime	Reads the water, the weather and the coastguard the same way.	the car

TRADE	LEANS ON	COMES WITH	WHAT THEY DO	ON THE MAP
Diver	NRV	Maritime	Works under the hull, in the dark, on a bottle and a clock.	the room
Climber	MUS	Logistics	Takes the outside of a building, because the inside is watched.	the way in
Tunneller	MUS	Logistics	Comes up through the floor, weeks after starting.	the room
Chemist	TCH	Medicine	Makes it, kills it, or makes it look like neither happened.	the room
Medic	BRN	Medicine	Keeps people on their feet long enough to finish the job.	the car
Electrician	TCH	Networks	Takes a building's power without taking its alarms.	the post
Signals	TCH	Networks	Jams, spoofs and listens to everything on the air.	the post
Analyst	BRN	Finance	Finds the eleven minutes in a year when nobody is looking.	the post
Quartermaster	BRN	Logistics	The right kit, in the right country, before anybody asks for it.	the street
Linguist	CHM	Politics	Speaks the room, whatever the room speaks.	the way in
Handler	CHM	Politics	Runs the person on the inside, and keeps them running.	the way in

They are found the same way as anybody else — Roster, then the trade filter, which lists all thirty. The filter is the only screen that separates them; a specialist's dossier looks like everybody else's.

4.4 Experience

Five ranks, earned by going on jobs — never bought. Each rank is worth +11% of everything the member's attributes are worth, which compounds with a good trade match rather than replacing it.

RANK	EXPERIENCE NEEDED	WHAT IT IS WORTH
Rookie	—	+0% on the reckoning
Operator	60 xp	+11% on the reckoning
Professional	180 xp	+22% on the reckoning
Veteran	430 xp	+33% on the reckoning
Legend	900 xp	+44% on the reckoning — and only a Respected name gets one to sign

Experience also decides what they cost: their fee and their cut both rise with it, and so does their weekly upkeep. A Legend is not simply better, they are better and more expensive in three different places on the same screen.

4.5 Knowledge

Ten domains. A posting names one or two it wants. Somebody on the crew who has it is worth +5; somebody who has it *and* studied to at least a degree is worth +10. Nobody with it at all is -6, per domain.

DOMAIN	WHAT A JOB WANTS IT FOR
Finance	Ledgers, accounts, where money actually sits.
Law	Papers, borders, what a warrant can and cannot do.
Networks	Systems, cameras, cold wallets.
Logistics	Routes, shipping, how a thing gets from here to there.

DOMAIN	WHAT A JOB WANTS IT FOR
Art	Provenance, what a thing is worth and to whom.
Politics	Who to call, who owes whom.
Medicine	Bodies, drugs, what a hospital notices.
Weapons	What is in the room and what it does.
Maritime	Ports, hulls, tides, manifests.
Aviation	Aircraft, airfields, flight plans.

4.6 Schooling

Six levels. Schooling counts for nothing at all on a job that does not lean on Brains, and counts a lot on one that does — any job whose Brains weight is 3 or more adds education × 1.2 to that member's own figure.

SCHOOLING	COUNTS FOR
No schooling	+0.0 on a job that leans on Brains
Street-schooled	+1.2 on a job that leans on Brains
Trade school	+2.4 on a job that leans on Brains
University	+3.6 on a job that leans on Brains
Military academy	+4.8 on a job that leans on Brains
Doctorate	+6.0 on a job that leans on Brains

4.7 Temperament

Most files have none, some have one, a few have two. They are the only thing on a file that changes how the crew behaves rather than how good they are.

TEMPERAMENT	WHAT IT DOES
Steady	Takes a bad night without losing faith — loyalty never drops when a job goes wrong.

Hothead	Worth +3 in the field and costs +4 heat every time out. Somebody always remembers the noise.
Careful	−4 heat on any job this one works. Gloves, timings, and a route home.
Quick study	Learns at double speed — twice the experience from every job.
Mentor	+2 in the field, and everyone else on the job learns half again as much.
Mercenary	+2 in the field and takes 3% more of every score. Nothing personal.
Lucky	The roll falls their way: +4 on the night, whatever the plan says.
Jinx	−3 on the night, and things go wrong around this one more often than they should.
Ghost	Never the one the police get their hands on. Somebody else is always closer to the door.

4.8 Limits

What somebody will not do. A limit is absolute — no bonus, no loyalty and no amount of money moves it, and a member whose limit the job hits simply does not go. A crew of six where four are claustrophobic is a crew of two underground.

LIMIT	KEEPS THEM OFF
Cannot swim	any job tagged on the water
Will not fly	any job tagged by air
Fear of heights	any job tagged at height
Claustrophobic	any job tagged underground
No violence	any job tagged violent
Won't work nights	any job tagged at night
Banned from the EU	any job in the EU
Wanted in the United States	any job in the United States
Won't work under authoritarian rule	any job under authoritarian rule

Demands 15% or walks

nothing — but they will not sign for under 15%

Limits are the single most common reason a job cannot be run at full strength, and the **Who goes** list on every job file names the limit by name against the person it stops.

4.9 **Passport, nationality and the border**

Everybody carries a passport, and passports are not equal. Countries are rated by how hard they are to enter: open, needs a visa, or strict.

- A **local national** always gets in, and is worth +8 to the job for knowing the ground.
- A **strict** border turns back anyone whose passport is better than **strong**.
- A border that **needs a visa** turns back anyone whose passport is weak.
- Time inside counts against you at a border: three years for a strict country, five for a visa country.
- A **Forger** on the crew — one who is not themselves barred from that country — clears all of it. That is what a Forger is for.

4.10 **Languages**

Somebody on the crew who speaks the local language is worth +6. Nobody who does is -8 — or -14 if the job is one of the talking kinds, where the whole thing is a conversation and there is no version of it that works in mime.

4.11 **What people cost you**

MONEY	WHEN	WHAT IT IS
The fee	Once, when they sign	What it takes to get them on the books. Scales with experience, attributes, knowledge, schooling and whether their trade is a scarce one.
The cut	Every job they go on	A percentage of the whole fee, off the top, before you see any of it. Roughly 3% at Rookie, rising about 1.2 points per experience rank, with a little jitter. A Mercenary takes 2 points more; somebody who demands 15% takes at least that.
The upkeep	Every week, forever	Wages. Paid whether they work, sit benched, are injured or are in a cell. This is the number that quietly ends careers.

Miss the payroll and everybody on the books loses 9 loyalty, every retainer stops answering, and the float is set to zero. It is the worst single thing that can happen to you without a job being involved.

4.12 Loyalty

0 to 100, and it starts somewhere between 42 and 68. It decides whether somebody stays when another crew buys them a drink, and how likely they are to talk once they are off the books.

WHAT MOVES IT	HOW MUCH
A messy job	-3 to everyone who went
A botched job	-7
A blown job — a disaster	-13
A missed payroll	-9 to everybody on the books
A bonus	+14, and three weeks paid up
Your ranking	Nobody: -1 a week. Known: nothing. Respected and up: +1. Untouchable and up: +2.

Being cut loose

-6, and then they are a loose end

Paid up is worth having for reasons beyond the loyalty: for 3 weeks after a bonus they are worth +2 on every reckoning, deaf to other crews, and not the one trouble picks on.

Restless is the opposite. A cut worth less than a week of what they cost you is a job they did for you rather than for themselves. Three of those in a row and they grumble — -2 each on every job — and five and they may walk.

4.13 **Greed, moles and vetting**

Roughly one file in fourteen belongs to an informant. They look like everybody else. A mole on the books leaks +3 heat a week, unexplained, and is very much more likely to talk once they are off the books.

Vetting costs \$6K and can be done from the roster before you ever fly out to meet somebody. It usually finds them. It is less reliable when nobody on your crew is sharp — with no one above 55 Brains in the field there is about a one-in-three chance a mole comes back clean.

Greed is a hidden number between 15 and 90. It does not change what they are worth on a job. It changes what they do when the job is over: a greedy member is likelier to take a cut of the score and vanish, and likelier to talk afterwards.

5.1 **The first week — the clock stands still**

Going to fetch somebody is a week on the ground — but not in week one.

While you are still putting the crew together you can go and ask as many people as the float carries, one after another, and the clock does not move.

Nothing about it is free. Every fee you agree to comes out of the float the moment they say yes, and a float spent in week one is a float you do not have in week four. What week one costs you is money, never time — which is the only sense in which it is cheap.

From **week two** every trip costs its week, whether they sign or not. That is what makes an empty place expensive rather than merely untidy, and it is why somebody turning up on their own is worth something.

5.2 **When they come to you**

From a **Known** name, people start asking to join instead. The chance is printed on the roster, and it rises with every rung above that — nobody comes to a Nobody.

It is the whole transaction the other way round, and that is the point of it:

- **No trip and no week.** They are already here.

- **The figure is theirs to open with and yours to argue with.** What they ask already sits under what going to fetch them would have cost — both are printed, side by side. **Too much** costs nothing to say and works most of the time, twice; the third time they are entitled to hold, and do.
- **No costs nothing.** No week, no money, no place. They go, and will not ask again for a month or two.
- And somebody who asked to be here starts a few points of loyalty ahead of somebody who had to be persuaded.

They only turn up when there is a place free. An applicant you cannot sign is a tease, not an event.

5.3 The roster

Everybody for hire, filterable by trade, experience, nationality, price and what they will not do. They are generated once from the game's seed and they do not change — the person you looked at in week 3 and could not afford is still there in week 40, at the same price, unless somebody else got to them.

5.4 Who will sign

Your ranking decides the ceiling. A Nobody cannot get a Legend to sit down with them at any price.

- **Nobody** and **Small time**: nobody above Professional.
- **Known**: up to Veteran.
- **Respected** and above: anybody, including Legends.

Somebody who turns you down will not meet you again for a set number of weeks, and the roster says which week.

5.5 **The recruitment trip**

You do not click *hire* and get a person. You fly out to where they are and sit down with them, and it runs as a live report exactly like a job does: a clock in the corner, a map of the city with the meeting on it, and the thing unfolding line by line.

- 1. You land, and the city is described as it actually is — its money, its weather, its politics.
- 2. You walk it for a day. What you notice depends on who you brought.
- 3. You sit down. Speaking the language, having a Face along, being a name people have heard of — each of them changes how the table goes.
- 4. Something happens. Not always, but often.
- 5. They sign, or they do not.

Nothing is paid until the signature. The fee leaves your float at the end of the meeting and not before, so a trip that ends in nothing ends in nothing — plus whatever the snag itself cost you.

5.6 **The snag**

Five kinds, and which one you get depends on who you are meeting:

SNAG	WHEN IT HAPPENS
Somebody else is at the table	Anyone. A rival crew got there first.
They want to test you	Only the good ones — Veteran and Legend.
It is a set-up	Greedy, or an informant, or six years inside or more.
They are not what the file says	Low experience, or low loyalty. Usually drunk.
A check at the hotel	Any country that needs a visa, is strict, or is under authoritarian rule.

Every snag offers several ways out, and which ones are open depends on what you brought with you — a Forger's papers, a Face making a call, an Enforcer, the local language, or simply a record long enough that they have heard of you. There is always at least one option available, and walking away is always one of them.

5.7 **Cutting somebody loose**

Dropping a member costs them 6 loyalty and puts them straight back on the roster at their original price. It also makes them a loose end, which is a separate conversation that the game will make you have.

6.1 Places

You start with four soldiers' places and yourself — five. A **Respected** name (ranking 65) opens two more, for six soldiers and you. That is the ceiling: 6 soldiers, plus the commander.

Those two places are not only more people. They are the only thing standing between you and the 500 operations — work that needs six or seven in the field, written for trades that no ordinary posting asks for. The game announces both at the same moment, in that order: the places first, then what they are for.

6.2 Who goes

Everybody on the books goes on every job, unless something stops them. There is no picking a team. What there is instead is a list of reasons somebody cannot go:

- A **limit** the job hits — the tag is named against them.
- A **border** their passport or their record will not get them through.
- They are **injured**, and the file says which week they are back.
- They are at a school — a new craft or a new language — and the file says which week it ends, and which one they are at.
- They are **held** by the police.
- You **benched** them.

The job file states, at the top, how many the client needs and how many can actually go. Under the needed number the whole crew is –22 per missing body, which is enormous — it is usually the single largest number in the factor list, and it is the reason a job you are short for is not worth running at any fee.

6.3 A new craft

A trade is what somebody *is* in this game: the first line of their card, and the thing a client asks for by name. So it can be changed, and changing it is a conversation rather than a purchase — **Teach a trade** on their card opens it.

Anybody Professional or better can be asked. What it costs:

- **Money** — from \$30K, more for a higher rank, and about twice as much for one of the specialists.
- **Weeks** — three to five out of the field, five to seven for a specialist. They cannot go on a job while they are at it.
- **Rank** — they come back **two ranks lower**, at the new trade, and are no longer the old one. A Legend Safecracker becomes a Professional Hacker.

And they can say no. The screen prints the chance they agree before you ask, and what it is made of: where you stand with them, what they are being asked to give up, whether they are built for the new work, and their temperament.

Where you stand is loyalty plus the nights you have actually been through together — it is not the same number as loyalty, and it is the one that decides this.

Ask and be refused and they will not hear it again for a month or two. Rank matters on both sides of it: a Professional gives up less than a Legend does, and answers accordingly.

6.4 And if they say no

Four directions, and which of them is worth taking is decided by the same number the refusal was.

- **Leave it.** Costs nothing, buys nothing, and they know you asked and listened. Loyalty +3.
- **Put money on it.** Three offers, each printing the new chance. **The money goes whether they take it or not** — that is what makes it an offer rather than a purchase. It moves the number at any standing, including for somebody who is halfway out of the door, but it never buys the last stretch.
- **Tell them it is not a question.** Three ways it can go, all printed: they go and resent it (-22 loyalty, and it costs you with them), they refuse in front of everybody, or they walk out that night. An Enforcer on the books moves the odds towards the first and away from the last.
- **Cut them loose.** They go, the crew takes it badly in proportion to how much they liked them, and they leave knowing what they know — see loose ends.

6.5 A new language

The other school, and the cheap one. **Teach a language** on their card opens it. It exists because of one line on every job file: a posting in a country nobody on the crew speaks is -8 on the night, and -14 if the job is all talk. One of your people speaking it is +6 instead. So the screen opens with the languages a posting wants *this week* that nobody on this crew can speak.

Nobody refuses this one. A trade is what somebody is, so swapping it costs rank and has to be argued for. A language is added to what they already have and takes nothing away — so there is nothing to argue about. It is a price list, and the price is weeks.

WHAT IT COSTS

Money	\$3K a week of tutoring — a fraction of a trade
Weeks, near	3 weeks for a language out of a family they are already inside
Weeks, far	6 weeks for one out of a family they are not
The field	they cannot go on a job while they are at it — the crew is one short
Coming back	the language, for good, and +4 loyalty for the money you spent on them

The families. A French speaker reaches Spanish, Italian, Portuguese, Romanian and Catalan across a family they are already in, and Japanese across nothing at all:

- **Romance** — French, Spanish, Portuguese, Italian, Romanian, Catalan.
- **Germanic** — English, German, Dutch, Swedish, Danish, Norwegian, Icelandic, Afrikaans.
- **Slavic** — Russian, Ukrainian, Polish, Czech, Slovak, Bulgarian, Serbian, Croatian, Slovenian.
- **Indo-Aryan** — Hindi, Urdu, Bengali, Punjabi, Gujarati, Marathi, Nepali, Sinhala.
- **Sino-Tibetan** — Mandarin, Cantonese, Burmese, Tibetan.
- **Turkic** — Turkish, Azerbaijani, Uzbek, Kazakh, Turkmen, Kyrgyz.
- **Austronesian** — Indonesian, Malay, Tagalog, Filipino, Javanese, Malagasy, Maori, Hawaiian.
- **Semitic** — Arabic, Hebrew. **Bantu** — Swahili, Zulu.

- **On their own** — Greek, Finnish, Japanese, Korean, Thai, Vietnamese.

Nothing in this game is near them, so they are always the long way round.

A week comes off for **Brains 70** or better, a week for **Quick study**, and a week for a **Linguist**, who does this for a living. Nothing is learned in under 2 weeks however sharp they are.

Every reason for the length is printed on the screen beside the number, including which language of theirs the new one is reached through.

6.6 Two of the same trade

Put two of the same trade on one crew and the question of who is *the* Safecracker is asked the same day, not eventually. It arrives as a scene — ten of them, and which one you get depends on the pair — and you have to answer it before you do anything else.

What it can be about: two plans for the same door; kit bought on the float that the other one says is wrong; one posting that wants the trade and two people who could take it; the newer one being on a bigger percentage; one treating the other as an apprentice; a client who asked for one of them by name; two schools of the same craft; a fourteen-month sentence one of them served for the other one's night; a safe house with one room; and a favour being called in at the table.

Each has five ways out — 50 between them — and every one states what it needs, what it costs and the odds it goes your way. They run from picking a side to paying one of them off, putting one on the bench, sending one to the second crew, having a Fixer or an Enforcer settle it, or asking one of them to learn a different trade, which is the only answer that removes the reason for the argument.

An answer either settles it or does not, and the screen says which. What is not settled comes back in a few weeks as a different scene between the same two people. Bad blood set here is the game's ordinary bad blood: it costs the crew on the reckoning of every job they are both out on.

6.7 **Benching**

Benching somebody keeps their percentage of the fee. That is all it does.

It does not save their wages. The payroll is charged every week for everybody on the books, benched or not, for as many weeks as the job holds the crew. The job file shows both numbers side by side — what the cuts cost and what the weeks cost — for exactly this reason.

Benching also lowers the crew size bonus, and it removes whatever that person was bringing: their trade, their language, their knowledge, their passport. The file recalculates the odds live as you bench people, so you can see the trade being made rather than guessing at it.

6.8 **Injured and held**

A bad night puts people in hospital or in a cell. A doctor on retainer halves the weeks of an injury; a lawyer on retainer halves the weeks of a sentence. Somebody who comes out of a cell is back on the roster rather than on your crew, a year older, with that year on their record — and a record is what borders read.

6.9 **A second crew**

From two years in, with a big enough name and a full crew, you can found a second crew that works without you.

NEEDED	VALUE
Week	104 for the second, 156 for the third, 208 for the fourth — and no more
Ranking	at least 80
Your crew	full — all 6 soldiers plus you
Among them	a commander type, and 5 ready to go

A crew is a commander and four soldiers, named after its commander. It takes a posting of its own each week from the same board. Its take is yours, its ranking is yours, its heat is yours — and so is its payroll.

7.1 The postings

Seven postings are kept open at all times — nine with a fixer on retainer, and one of those nine is written for the crew you actually have. They expire. A posting you were saving for next week may not be there next week.

Clients post to a **name**. A Nobody sees tier 1 and 2 only; a Known crew sees tier 3; Respected and above see everything. A client you have botched a job for stops posting to you at all.

7.2 Tiers

Four of them on the open board, and the tier decides the fee, how many weeks it holds the crew, how many people the client needs, and how long you are allowed to sit outside it first.

TIER	POSTINGS CALLED	TYPICAL FEE	WEEKS ON THE GROUND	WEEKS YOU MAY CASE IT
1	small	\$52K ×1.42 per week	1 week	1
2	middling	\$150K ×1.42 per week	1 week	2
3	big	\$380K ×1.42 per week	2 weeks	3
4	the big rooms	\$950K ×1.42 per week	3 weeks	4

The fee is then multiplied by the country's economy (a poor country pays about two thirds), by your ranking's pay multiplier, and by a wide random band. Two postings of the same tier can differ by a factor of three.

There is a fifth tier. No client posts it and no rival takes it — see the operations.

7.3 **The twelve kinds of job**

Each kind leans on some attributes and not others. This table is the reason to read a posting before you open it: a crew that is magnificent at one of these is ordinary at another.

KIND OF JOB	WHAT IT LEANS ON
Interception	NRV×3 MUS×2 BRN×1
Recovery	BRN×3 NRV×2 CHM×1
Extraction	MUS×3 NRV×3
Escort	MUS×3 NRV×2 BRN×1
Surveillance	BRN×3 TCH×3
Infiltration	CHM×3 NRV×2 BRN×2 — <i>and this one is all talk, so the language matters double</i>
Cyber	TCH×4 BRN×2
Smuggling	NRV×3 MUS×2
Papers	BRN×3 CHM×2 TCH×1
Negotiation	CHM×4 BRN×2 — <i>and this one is all talk, so the language matters double</i>
Sabotage	TCH×3 MUS×2 NRV×2
Vault	BRN×3 TCH×2 NRV×2

Operations add eight more kinds, which only they use.

7.4 **What a job is**

Six tags, and each of them is a limit somebody on your crew might have.

TAG	READS AS
water	on the water
air	by air
heights	at height
underground	underground
violence	violent
night	at night

7.5 Countries

Forty-nine of them, and each one is a real place with its own languages, currency, economy, politics, terrain, cities and border. Which kinds of job appear there follows from what the country is.

Local heat is separate from your own. Working a country adds +14 to it and it falls 1 a week. Every point of it makes jobs in that country +0.34 harder. Work the same country five weeks running and you have made it your hardest country.

7.6 Casing a job

A room you have watched is not the room you were told about. Each week of casing is worth +9 on the night.

- It costs 6% of the fee, minimum \$4K.
- It spends a week — the payroll is charged, the world moves.
- It adds +2 heat and +3 local heat.
- You may case a tier-1 posting once and a tier-4 posting four times.

- **The posting can be gone when you look up.** The rival works the same board, and clients stop waiting.

7.7 **How hard a job is**

Every posting carries a difficulty, and the crew has to beat it. It is built like this:

PART	VALUE
Base	25
Per tier	+16 × tier
Jitter	±7
Your ranking	+19 per 100 ranking, slightly sub-linear — at 420 the world is about +62 harder
Local heat	+0.34 a point
A strict border	+5
Authoritarian rule	+4

The ranking term is the important one, and it is the game's spine: **the rooms you are offered are defended against the name you have built.** A crew that does not keep improving does not stand still — it slides.

QUICK MONEY - HIGH RISK

8

CHAPTER 8 · ONE PERSON, NO CREW, NO PLAN

8.1 What it is

A box under the postings on the Jobs board, headed **Quick Money - High Risk**: two or three small pieces a week, a few hundred to a few thousand dollars each, done this afternoon by **one** person off your books. No client, no casing, no crew, no plan, and no week spent.

It exists for one situation, and it is a situation everybody ends up in: **you are a few thousand short of the person you need**. The file is there, the price is there, and the float is not. This is how you make up the difference, and it is meant to feel like it.

8.2 The whole game of it is who you send

A trade counts for **nothing** out here. Nobody is paying for a Safecracker on a parked car, and a Legend Forger is worth no more than anybody else on a scaffolding roof.

What counts is:

- **The attributes the work actually leans on**, weighted — three parts nerve and one part technique is a different person from three parts muscle.
- **Experience**, which is worth +3 a rank. Somebody who has done this before does this better.
- **Temperament**. A Ghost is +8 and a Hothead is -7, because this is work with nobody behind them and no way out that somebody else planned.

- **What they will not do.** A limit is not a penalty here, it is a wall: somebody afraid of heights is not going up the scaffolding, and the button says so.

The commander is -6 and is not on the list at all — you do not go. You are used to having four people behind you, and there is nobody behind you here.

8.3 **The odds, before you choose**

Every name on the list carries its own percentage, worked out against this particular piece of work, next to the fit that produced it. That is the same promise the rest of the game makes: the number is on the option before you take it, not after.

Fit against the work's difficulty gives a margin, and the margin gives the chance they come back with the money. The margin does something else as well — **the worse the fit, the worse the wrong ending**. A bad choice is not merely likelier to fail. It is likelier to cost you the person.

8.4 **What it costs when it goes wrong**

- **Hurt** — out of the field for two weeks, one with a doctor on retainer.
- **Taken** — held for two to five weeks, one to three with a lawyer. They come off the crew while they are inside.
- **Nothing but the walk home** — no money, no damage. The commonest bad ending, and the cheapest.
- Either way: **heat**, global and local, whether or not it came off. The street does not care how it went. And loyalty -4, because you sent them out alone.

8.5 What is on offer

Twelve kinds of work, two or three of them a week, in a different city each time and at a price and a difficulty that are drawn fresh.

THE WORK	LEANS ON	DIFFICULTY	PAYS	IF IT GOES WRONG	HEAT	NOT FOR
Work the crowd at the terminus	CHM×2 NRV×2 BRN×1	34	\$900– \$2,600	hurt 10% · taken 14%	+3	—
Take the car with the engine running	NRV×3 TCH×1 MUS×1	38	\$1,400– \$3,800	hurt 13% · taken 16%	+5	—
The till at closing	NRV×2 MUS×2 CHM×1	40	\$1,200– \$3,200	hurt 18% · taken 15%	+6	No violence
A parcel off the back of a van	NRV×2 MUS×2 BRN×1	32	\$800– \$2,400	hurt 9% · taken 12%	+3	—
Strip the meter cupboards	TCH×3 MUS×1 BRN×1	30	\$700– \$2,100	hurt 14% · taken 10%	+2	Claustrophobic
Go up the scaffolding for the lead	MUS×3 NRV×2	36	\$1,100– \$3,000	hurt 24% · taken 8%	+2	Fear of heights
Sell somebody else's stock to somebody else	CHM×3 BRN×2	42	\$1,600– \$4,200	hurt 7% · taken 18%	+4	—
Run a tab and a story	CHM×3 BRN×1 NRV×1	33	\$600– \$1,900	hurt 4% · taken 13%	+2	—
The left luggage lockers	BRN×3 TCH×2	35	\$900– \$2,700	hurt 5% · taken 17%	+4	—

THE WORK	LEANS ON	DIFFICULTY	PAYS	IF IT GOES WRONG	HEAT	NOT FOR
The office floor at three in the morning	NRV×3 BRN×1 TCH×1	37	\$1,000– \$2,900	hurt 6% · taken 19%	+5	Won't work nights
Two motorcycles from a covered yard	MUS×2 TCH×2 NRV×1	34	\$1,300– \$3,400	hurt 11% · taken 14%	+4	—
Collect somebody else's debt for a cut	MUS×3 CHM×1 NRV×1	39	\$1,500– \$4,000	hurt 22% · taken 11%	+5	No violence

Coming back clean is worth +6 experience. This is the cheapest way there is to put a rank on somebody you have just signed — which is its own reason to send the right person rather than the spare one.

8.6 Why you cannot live on it

One piece of street work a week, however big your crew. That is the whole of the brake, and it is deliberate.

A perfect year of it — fifty-two weeks, every one of them clean, never once losing anybody — comes to about a fifth of what three tier-3 jobs pay. It is not an income. It is the difference between a file you cannot afford this week and a file you can, and it is bought with a real chance of losing the most expensive thing you own, which is a person.

9.1 What an operation is

A **Respected** name (ranking 65) opens the last two places on your crew. It opens something else at the same time, and the two are one thing: work written for a crew of that size, which nobody could field before and which you could not have been offered.

There are 500 of them. They are numbered OP-001 to OP-500, they are marked **Operation** on the board, and **each one exists once**: run it and it is gone from your game for good. The job file counts them down for you — *Operation 3 of 500* — so you always know how much of it is left.

	A TIER-4 JOB	AN OPERATION
In the field	4 to 5	6 or 7 — and one that wants seven is +8 on the difficulty
Weeks on the ground	3	3 to 5
Trades named	1 to 2	3 to 5, most of them specialists
Knowledge named	1	2 to 3
Weeks you may case it	4	5
Base fee	\$950K	\$2.4M
Base difficulty	set by tier and country	122 before country and name
Heat it makes	by tier	34

	A TIER-4 JOB	AN OPERATION
How many exist	as many as clients post	500, and each is run once

Everything else about them works the way ordinary work works. The reckoning is the same arithmetic, the verdict bands are the same, the twist can still arrive, the split is the same split, and a botched one makes the same enemy. What is different is the size of all of it.

9.2 How they arrive

Once the seventh place is open, one or two operations sit on the board at any time, alongside the ordinary postings — they do not replace them. They expire like anything else, and a new one takes the place of one that lapses.

- **No client posts them.** They come from a short list of people who do not use the board.
- **The rival never takes one.** Every other posting on the board is a race; these are not. They wait for you.
- **A client you have fallen out with still keeps theirs off your board** — a grudge silences an operation the same way it silences a job.
- **One you have run never comes back.** The counter on the file is the honest one: it counts what you have spent, not what you have seen.

The record in the Log carries an **Operations** line from the week the first one opens, and it reads n of 500 — the only number in the game that only goes one way.

9.3 The eight kinds

Operations use eight kinds of job of their own, and no ordinary posting ever uses them. Each is built around a place a crew of five could not reach.

KIND OF JOB	WHAT IT LEANS ON
Deep water	NRV×4 MUS×2 TCH×2
Air lift	NRV×4 TCH×3 BRN×2
High rise	MUS×3 NRV×3 TCH×3
Under the city	MUS×4 TCH×3 BRN×2
Blackout	TCH×5 BRN×3
The long con	CHM×5 BRN×3 — <i>and this one is all talk, so the language matters double</i>
Lab work	TCH×4 BRN×3 NRV×2
The whole ledger	BRN×5 TCH×3 CHM×2

The country follows the kind rather than the other way round: **Deep water** and **Air lift** are written for coasts and for distance, so the map decides where they can happen. The seven-place operations ask for 3 to 5 trades and 2 to 3 kinds of knowledge, which is more than any one person carries — that is what the extra places are for.

9.4 **What to take**

An operation names its trades, and most of what it names is a specialist. That is the whole shape of the thing: six or seven in the field, three to five trades asked for by name, each worth +14 to whoever matches it. A crew of generalists can be sent on one; it will not be the crew the file was written for.

Read the file before you hire for it. The trades are listed on the posting, the roster's trade filter has all thirty in it, and a specialist you sign for a \$2.4M room is cheap at \$9K over the odds.

Seven in the field is worth +8 of difficulty over six. More people is not free — the operations that ask for seven are the ones that are hard because they need seven.

10.1 What one person is worth

For the job in front of them — not in general:

1. Take their five attributes, weighted by what this kind of job leans on, and divide by the total weight.
 2. Multiply by $1 + (\text{experience} - 1) \times 0.11$.
 3. Add 14 if the client asked for their trade.
 4. Add $\text{education} \times 1.2$ if this job's Brains weight is 3 or more.

The crew's **power** is the average of that across everybody who actually goes. An average, not a sum — which is why one brilliant specialist does not carry four passengers, and why adding a body who is wrong for the job makes the crew worse rather than bigger.

10.2 The factors

On top of the average comes a list of adjustments, and the job file shows every one of them with its number and its reason. This is the whole list:

FACTOR	WORTH
Crew short	−22 per missing body
Crew size	+6, plus 3 per spare body over the needed number, capped at +9
You command	your command score, normally +5
Commanders under you	−3 each
Stand-in leader	their command −2, minimum 1 — only when you cannot get in

FACTOR	WORTH
Leaderless	-10
Language	+6 spoken, -8 not, -14 not on a talking job
Local national	+8
Knows a domain	+5, or +10 if schooled in it
Nobody knows a domain	-6 each
Trades	+4 per wanted trade present
Paid up	+2 each, capped at +6
Temperament	whatever the traits in the field are worth
They have worked together	a point per job the pair has finished together
Bad blood	a point off per botched or blown night the pair shared
Restless	-2 each
Cased	+9 per week watched
Heat	-0.24 per point of heat — at heat 80 that is -19

10.3 The night

Add the factors to the power. Subtract the job's difficulty. That is the **margin** — what the job file shows as the odds.

On the night, a roll of ± 26 is added to the margin, and where it lands decides the verdict. The width of that roll is why the file quotes five percentages rather than a yes or a no: a margin of +20 is a good job that can still be messy.

VERDICT	THE NIGHT	PAYS	RANKING	HEAT	FALLOUT
CLEAN	above 34	the fee and 8% over	up, most	$\times 0.5$	nobody touched
SUCCESS	above 8	the fee	up	$\times 0.85$	—
MESSY	above -12	60% of the fee	down a little	$\times 1.25$	loyalty -3

VERDICT	THE NIGHT	PAYS	RANKING	HEAT	FALLOUT
BOTCHED	above -36	nothing	down	×1.5	one hurt or held, loyalty -7
DISASTER	below -36	nothing	down hard	×1.9	two or three hurt or held, loyalty -13

A clean night pays 8% over the fee — the client is pleased and rounds up. A messy one pays 60%. A botched or blown one pays nothing at all, and the wages for those weeks still come out of your float.

10.4 **What a job leaves behind**

Every verdict moves more than the money:

- **Ranking** up or down, damped by how far beneath your name the job was. A tier-1 posting run by a Notorious crew barely registers.
- **Heat**, the job's own figure multiplied by the verdict's own multiplier and again by your ranking's.
- **Local heat** in that country, +14.
- **Experience** to everyone who went, doubled for a Quick study, and half again for everyone on a job with a Mentor on it.
- **Attributes**, occasionally, on whatever the job leaned on.
- **People** hurt or held, on a botched or blown night.
- **Loyalty**, down, on anything worse than a success.
- **Bad blood** or a bond, between every pair who were there.
- **A client with a grudge**, if you blew their job — and they may come back for it.

THE NIGHT ITSELF

CHAPTER 11 · THE LIVE REPORT

11.1 **Reading the report**

A job does not resolve into a number. It plays out: a clock in the top left, a line at a time, with the crew named and what each of them is doing named with them. You can run it at five speeds, hold it where it is with Pause, or press through it as fast as you can read.

11.2 **The map**

Beside the report is the world, drawn in ink — the country the job is in, with the sites of the job on it and your people standing at them, as faces, with a small symbol for what they are doing.

The plan has five positions, and which one somebody stands at follows from their trade:

ON THE PLAN	WHO STANDS THERE
The street	whoever the line is about
The post	Hacker, Fixer, Lookout, Launderer, Overwatch
The way in	Grifter, Forger, Infiltrator, Pickpocket, Face
The room	Safecracker, Enforcer, Demolitions
The car	Wheelman, Cleaner, Smuggler

A recruitment trip gets the same treatment, with four positions instead: landing, the city, the table, and the deal.

11.3 **The twist**

Most jobs go wrong in the middle. The report stops, states the problem, and offers up to six ways out — each one with the odds on it and a requirement written into it. One of them is always something your crew can actually do.

The options are gated on what you brought: a trade, an attribute above a threshold, the language, or a long enough record. Choosing the option that fits your crew is worth a great deal; choosing the impressive one you cannot back up is how a good job becomes a blown one.

A twist you walk away from mid-decision is not lost. Close the game in the middle of it and it resumes exactly there — the report so far, then the options.

11.4 **WHAT WENT WRONG**

When a job ends botched or blown, the report adds a section that reads back the actual reckoning and says, in order of how much it cost, what beat you — and for each of those, what would have fixed it. Not advice in general: the trade that was wanted and missing, the language nobody spoke, the domain nobody knew, the bodies you were short, the weeks you did not spend watching it, the heat you carried in.

12.1 The split

The fee is not yours. Everybody who goes takes their percentage off the top and you keep the rest. The job file shows the whole thing before you commit:

- Every person who is going, with their percentage and what that is in money.
- What the crew takes altogether, and what is left for you.
- **The wages** — the weekly payroll and every retainer, multiplied by the weeks the job holds the crew.
- **What you should expect to keep:** every verdict's takings weighted by its own odds, with the crew's percentage off each, minus the wages. A botched job pays nothing but still costs its share of the odds — which is the whole reason benching for a bigger share can leave you with less.

12.2 Standing arrangements

A balance that only climbs is a balance doing nothing. These are charged every week out of the same payroll as the crew, and if you miss it they stop answering.

ARRANGEMENT	A WEEK	WHAT IT BUYS
A lawyer on retainer	\$12K	Anyone taken is out in half the weeks — a firm that answers the phone at four in the morning.
A doctor on call	\$9K	A wound is a week instead of two, and no questions asked about how it happened.

ARRANGEMENT	A WEEK	WHAT IT BUYS
A fixer on retainer	\$15K	Two more postings on the board each week, and one of them written for the crew you actually have.

The safe house is bought outright, once each, in order:

SAFE HOUSE	ONCE	WHAT IT BUYS
A lock-up behind a laundry	\$80K	Heat falls 7 a week instead of 5.
A flat nobody rented to you	\$200K	Heat falls 9 a week.
A yard, a name on a lease, two ways out	\$450K	Heat falls 11 a week, and a raid takes less of the float.

12.3 **A desk that forgets**

From heat 20 upwards a file can be lost. It costs what the heat is worth — about \$3K a point — and buys -20 heat and -12 off the detective's file.

HEAT AND THE LAW

13

CHAPTER 13 · BEING LOOKED FOR

13.1 Heat

A number from 0 to 120 measuring how hard the world is looking at you. Jobs add it. It falls 5 a week by itself, 7, 9 or 11 with a safe house.

Heat costs you -0.24 on every job, per point — at heat 80 every job is -19 before anybody has done anything. It is not a punishment meter; it is a difficulty dial that you turn yourself.

Laying low spends a week for -15 heat and -6 off the detective's file, and costs one point of ranking. A name unused is a name forgotten.

13.2 The detective

Once your heat has been up, or your name is big enough, somebody opens a file on your alias. They have a name, and the Dashboard tells you how thick the file is.

- It thickens by roughly $\text{heat} \div 22$ a week, and faster above heat 70.
- Below heat 25 it **thins** by 0.9 a week. A quiet month is a cold case.
- At 50 they can brief a squad. At 75 they can do it faster.
- Paying a desk, laying low, and a raid itself all thin it.

13.3 The raid

A raid comes when heat reaches 100 — or 90 once the file is at 50, or 80 once it is at 75. It takes one or two of your crew into a cell, takes 30% of your float — 15% with the best safe house — and drops your heat to 58.

A thick file does not raid you. It brings the raid *forward*. Those are different problems and they have different answers: heat is bought down with a bribe or a quiet week, a file is bought down with a bribe or time.

THE COMPETITION

14

CHAPTER 14 · SOMEBODY ELSE IS WORKING THE BOARD

14.1 The other outfit

Once you reach ranking 20, somebody else appears on the same board with their own boss, their own name and their own standing. They are not an event — they are a second player.

- Most weeks they take a posting off the board, and it is the **best one left**.
- Every posting they take raises their standing.
- When their standing is ahead of yours they take more often, and they start buying your crew drinks.

14.2 Being poached

While another crew is buying drinks, your least loyal member who is not paid up has a real chance of walking every week. Loyalty below 60 is the danger zone. A bonus makes somebody deaf to it for 3 weeks — which is the cheapest counter in the game.

14.3 What you can do about them

- **Buy a name inside** — costs at least \$40K, or their standing $\times$ \$3K, and takes 8 to 14 points off them. No heat.
- **Send the enforcer** — free, needs an Enforcer on the books. 65% it takes 12 to 20 points off them for +6 heat. 35% it goes loud in a street with windows: +16 heat, and they are not frightened.

15.1 What a week does

1. The payroll is charged — every member's upkeep and every retainer.
2. Moles leak +3 heat each.
3. Loyalty drifts by whatever your ranking is worth.
4. Another crew's drinks may take somebody.
5. The injured come back and the held walk out, if their week has come.
6. Heat falls. Local heat falls by 1 everywhere.
7. Weeks without a job accumulate; 3 of them costs a point of ranking.
8. The rival takes a posting. The detective writes.
9. Loose ends, grudges and revenge tick over.
10. A raid, if the heat has reached the number.
11. Every 3 to 7 weeks, something that is not a job.

15.2 **The week's paper**

Every week opens with the paper: three to five headlines from around the world, drawn off the save and the week, so the same week always prints the same page. Most of it is colour — an election called, a port fogged in, a cup final. In some weeks one or two headlines reach the board, and the paper says so with On the board under the story: dockers on strike shut a port and put a quarter on the fee for smuggling there; a summit makes every job in the country harder and hotter; a bank holiday makes the vaults easier; a controllers' strike grounds everything by air for the week. A posting the paper touches carries In the news on the board and says what changed on its file; a posting the paper shut cannot be run until next week. Next week's paper undoes this week's. The button in the top bar opens the paper again.

15.3 **Things that are not jobs**

Eight kinds, each with several ways out, each with its odds written on it.

BETWEEN JOBS	WHAT HAPPENS
A death on holiday	They went to the coast for three days. A boat, a storm, a phone that rings out. They is not coming back.
Gone without a word	They's flat is empty, the phone is dead, and the bar hasn't seen They in a week.
Somebody wants out	They says it's over: a partner, a kid, a bad dream. They is quitting — unless there's a reason not to.
Somebody has a new crew	They has gone to another crew — and is buying drinks for yours. Every week They is out there, somebody listens.
An old face - Blackmailing	They — who used to be on this crew — is back, broke, and talking about the police. \$15K buys silence.

BETWEEN JOBS	WHAT HAPPENS
A sit-down	their boss wants a table, two chairs and an hour. The word from another crew is that there is enough board for both of you — for a price.
Somebody talked to the police	A file with your alias in it came from outside. their boss's people have been talking to a detective.
A detective is asking	a detective has your alias in a folder and is asking around the bars.

When somebody threatens to walk, their whole file opens underneath the question — attributes, trade, experience, loyalty, what they have been through — so the decision is made about a person rather than a name. One of the options is to let them go and settle it in forty-eight hours.

An old face is always one of yours, and the screen opens with how they actually left — walked out over the money, asked to be let out, cut loose, gone to another crew, or away with a cut of a score. It is written on their file the week it happens, so a blackmail cannot describe a resignation as a robbery.

Which is how a death can come back. 25% of the deaths on that coast were arranged by the person who died, and the week they turn up asking for money is the week you find out — the boat, the storm and the phone that rang out were theirs, and if you paid for the funeral and the family, that money went with them. The other 75% really did drown. They are off the roster for good, and no blackmail is ever drawn on them.

15.4 **Loose ends**

Anybody who leaves the books alive knows things. The game will not let you ignore it — the question is put to you, once, per person, with the odds.

HOW THEY LEFT	CHANCE THEY TALK, BEFORE ADJUSTMENTS
Walked out over the money	26%

HOW THEY LEFT	CHANCE THEY TALK, BEFORE ADJUSTMENTS
Took a cut of the score and vanished	46%
Left for another crew	38%
Asked to be let out	18%
Was cut loose	20%

That figure is then raised by what they know, a long record, greed, and being an informant — a mole adds 20 points — and lowered by their loyalty. A Ghost is less likely to talk; a Hothead more.

The ways of dealing with it run from doing nothing to a contract, and every one of them names its own price, its own odds and what it costs you with the crew. The quiet answers need a specific trade on the books: a Cleaner, an Enforcer, or a Fixer. Without them, the list is much shorter and much worse.

15.5 **Grudges and revenge**

Blow a client's job and there is a real chance they take it personally — 62% on a disaster, 34% on a botch, 5% on a messy night.

- They stop posting to you, for 16 to 34 weeks.
- They may take one or two of their friends with them — other clients who stop posting too.
- And 42% of the time they do not merely stop. Something arrives, 2 to 6 weeks later.

The board says who, and why. A notice above the postings names every client who will not deal with you, and against each one: the job it was about, the city, the week, and which way the night went — or, for a client you have never worked for, which of the others had a word with them. Click the notice and the whole account opens: what they paid, what they lost, how many weeks are left, and whether this is one of the ones that is not finished with you.

A ban cannot be bought off. The one exception is a client who comes for you: paying back what they lost, in cash, on the spot, is one of the answers on that screen, and it ends the grudge there and then. Everything else is time.

16.1 The ladder

Eight names across 420 points. The last two rungs are most of the game.

RANKING	NAME	JOB'S PAY	POSTINGS UP TO	WILL SIGN	PLACES	HEAT	LOYALTY DRIFT
0	Nobody	-20%	tier 2	Professional	5	—	-1 a week
15	Small time	-10%	tier 2	Professional	5	—	0 a week
35	Known	+0%	tier 3	Veteran	6	—	0 a week
65	Respected	+10%	tier 4	Legend	7	+5%	+1 a week
110	Feared	+20%	tier 4	Legend	7	+10%	+1 a week
190	Notorious	+28%	tier 4	Legend	7	+14%	+1 a week
300	Untouchable	+38%	tier 4	Legend	7	+18%	+2 a week
420	The Crew	+50%	tier 4	Legend	7	+22%	+2 a week

16.2 What moves it

- Clean and successful work raises it — damped by how far beneath your name the job was.
- Messy work, leaks, arrests and walkouts lower it.
- 3 weeks without a job costs a point, and so does every week laid low.

Ranking is the thing the whole game is about, and it cuts both ways: it is the only way to open tier-4 work, get Legends to sign and reach the last score — and it makes every room harder, every police force more interested, and every posting on the board a fight. That is not a flaw in the design. That is the design.

17.1 The count

Every job, every verdict, every country, everything earned and everything paid out in cuts, the biggest single score, people hurt, taken and lost, and how often a twist was called right. All of it under **The record** on the Dashboard.

17.2 The marks

Eighteen of them. They are not achievements — each one pays, in ranking or in money or both, and the Dashboard keeps the next few in front of you.

MARK	WHAT IT TAKES	PAYS
The first job	Take a posting and see it through, however it goes.	ranking +2
A crew of five	Fill every seat your name allows.	ranking +2
Clean work	Bring one job home CLEAN — nothing left behind, nobody touched.	ranking +3 · \$25K
Six figures	Clear \$100K net on a single job.	ranking +3
A name that opens doors	Reach Known — ranking 40. Tier-3 postings and Veterans who will sign.	\$50K
The bigger table	Run a tier-3 job and come back with money.	ranking +4
Ten on file	Ten jobs in the case log, whatever the verdicts.	ranking +3 · \$40K
Cool under pressure	Call a twist right — the one move the crew you brought could actually make.	ranking +4
Five without a scratch	Five jobs in a row with nobody hurt, taken or gone.	ranking +5 · \$75K

MARK	WHAT IT TAKES	PAYS
A million on hand	Hold \$1M at once. What you do with it is the next question.	ranking +3
A Legend signs	Get an operative of Legend experience onto the crew.	ranking +4
Eight countries	Work in eight different countries.	ranking +4 · \$60K
The top of the board	Run a tier-4 job. Respected names only.	ranking +5
Feared	Reach ranking 80. Jobs pay a fifth more and the police look harder.	\$150K
Two crews	Found a crew of your own people that works without you.	ranking +5
Fifty on file	Fifty jobs run. Most people are caught long before this.	ranking +6 · \$250K
Five million	Hold \$5M at once.	ranking +5
The one that ends it	Take the final score and walk away from it.	—

18.1

Getting there

It does not appear until the four conditions are all true. The Dashboard ticks them off as they arrive. Each stage is tier 5, holds the crew for 4 weeks, and may be cased up to four times.

18.2

The three

STAGE	WHERE	WANTS	PAYS
Read the room where the names are kept	Zug, Switzerland	Hacker, Infiltrator, Forger · Finance, Politics · 4 people	\$1.8M
Open the floor below the floor	Zürich, four floors below the street	Safecracker, Demolitions, Overwatch · Finance, Weapons · 5 people	\$4.2M
Everything, and out	Zürich, then everywhere	Smuggler, Wheelman, Cleaner · Logistics, Maritime · 4 people	\$8M

They are run in order. A stage that fails is not the end — the Committee moves things, and that door is worth trying again after some weeks, which the Dashboard names.

Read what each stage wants and build for it before the first one opens. A crew assembled for tier-4 vault work is not a crew that can smuggle everything out of a country whose every border is a question with your face on it.

CONTROLS AND THE FILE CABINET

19

CHAPTER 19 · KEYS, SAVING, SETTINGS

19.1 The keys

KEY	WHAT IT DOES
Esc	The office — pause and settings. Also closes whatever is open.
≡ top right	The same.
1 2 3 4	Crew, Jobs, Roster, Dashboard.
Enter / Space	Open the posting you have selected.
i	Explain whatever is on screen, and run the tutorial again.

19.2 Saving

Automatic, in this browser, after everything. Settings are kept separately and survive a new game.

A game lives in one browser only. Clear its data, play on another machine, or lose the laptop, and the crew goes with it. The office's **file cabinet** writes the whole game out as one long code you can keep anywhere, and reads one back in — on this browser or any other. Reading a code in tells you whose file it is, which week and which ranking, *before* it replaces what is in the browser.

19.3 Settings

Sound, music, brightness and report speed, all in the office. The report speed runs from Slowest to Fastest — five settings, because reading a job as it happens and pressing through one you already understand are different things.

TWENTY-ONE THINGS WORTH KNOWING

20

CHAPTER 20 · EVERYTHING ABOVE, PUT TO USE

1. **Read the category before the fee.** The twelve kinds of job lean on different attributes. A crew of muscle is ordinary at anything the client wants talked through.
2. **Being short is worse than being weak.** -22 a body dwarfs everything else in the factor list. A job you cannot field is a job to skip, whatever it pays.
3. **Hire a Forger early.** Not for the +14 — for the borders. One Forger turns a crew of six passports into a crew that can work anywhere.
4. **Limits are permanent.** Check them before you sign, not the first time a posting is tagged underground and four of your people stay in the car.
5. **Vet the cheap ones.** \$6K against a mole who leaks heat every week and is very likely to talk on the way out is not a close call.
6. **Somebody sharp makes vetting work.** With nobody above 55 Brains in the field, a third of moles come back clean.
7. **Bonuses are the cheapest defence you have.** 3 weeks of +2 on every job, deafness to other crews, and immunity from being the one trouble picks on.
8. **Watch the small cuts.** Three jobs in a row where somebody's percentage is worth less than a week of their wages and they start grumbling; five and they walk.
9. **Case the big ones.** +9 a week for 6% of the fee is the best rate in the game — but the posting can be gone when you look up.

1. **Do not work the same country twice running.** +14 local heat a job, falling 1 a week, and every point of it is difficulty.
2. **Heat is a difficulty dial, not a punishment.** At 80 every job is -19. Buy it down before a big one, not after a raid.
3. **A thick file does not raid you — it moves the raid closer.** Heat and the file are two numbers with two different answers.
4. **Benching saves the cut and not the wages.** The whole payroll is charged for every week the job runs, benched or not.
5. **The expected-keep figure is the honest one.** It weights every verdict by its own odds and subtracts the wages. A bigger share of a job you will probably botch is less money.
6. **Take the twist option your crew can actually back up.** Every option states what it needs. The impressive one you cannot back is how a good job becomes a blown one.
7. **Read WHAT WENT WRONG.** It is not flavour — it names the factor that cost you the most and what would have fixed it.
8. **Keep pairs together.** A pair gains a point for every job that comes off with both of them on it. A long-running crew is worth real numbers.
9. **Bad blood is the same mechanism in reverse.** Hover it and the game tells you which nights caused it.
10. **Your ranking makes the world harder.** +19 difficulty per 100. A crew that stops improving is sliding.
11. **Quick money is for the gap, not for a living.** One a week, a few thousand at most — and send the person the work actually leans on, because a bad fit is not merely likelier to fail, it is likelier to cost you them.

1. **Start building for the last score before it opens.** It wants Hacker, Infiltrator, Forger, Safecracker, Demolitions, Overwatch, Smuggler, Wheelman and Cleaner across three operations — and \$5M of your own money.

Bad blood

What a pair has lost by sharing botched nights. Costs the crew points on every job they are both on. Hover it in the job file to read which nights did it.

Bench

Keeping somebody off a job. Saves their cut. Does not save their wages.

Bond

The opposite of bad blood: what a pair has gained by finishing jobs together.

Casing

Spending a week and 6% of the fee watching a posting before taking it. Worth 9 on the night, each week.

Command

Your own number, added to every job you go on. Starts at 5.

Cut

A crew member's percentage of a job's fee, taken off the top.

Difficulty

The number the crew has to beat. Built from the tier, your ranking, the local heat and the country.

Expected keep

What the job file says you should expect to walk away with, over many nights like this one: every verdict weighted by its own odds, minus the crew's cuts and the wages.

Fee (job)

What a client pays. Not what you keep.

Fee (member)

The one-off cost of getting somebody to sign.

Field

Everybody on the books who is fit and not in a cell.

File

The detective's file on your alias, 0 to 100. Thick files bring the raid forward.

Gate

How hard a country is to enter: open, needs a visa, or strict.

Grudge

A client who will not post to you any more, because you blew their job.

Heat

How hard the world is looking, 0 to 120. Subtracts from every job.

Local heat

The same thing, per country. Adds to the difficulty of jobs there.

Loose end

Somebody who left the books alive and knows things.

Margin

Your effective figure minus the job's difficulty. The number the odds are drawn from.

Mark

One of the eighteen things worth doing, on the Dashboard under The record. Each pays.

Mole

An informant on your books. About one file in fourteen. Leaks heat, and talks.

Paid up

Three weeks after a bonus. Worth +2, deaf to other crews, and not the one trouble picks on.

Payroll

Every crew member's upkeep plus every retainer, charged every week.

Places

Seats on the crew. Four soldiers and you to start, six and you at Respected.

Posting

A job on the board.

Power

The average of what everybody going is worth for this particular job.

Quick money

The box under the postings, **Quick Money - High Risk**: one person and no crew. One a week, a few thousand at most, and a real chance of losing them.

Raid

The police coming. At heat 100, or sooner with a thick file.

Ranking

Your name, 0 to 420. Decides everything.

Restless

Three jobs in a row whose cut was worth less than a week of their wages.

Retainer

A lawyer, a doctor or a fixer on the books at a weekly cost.

Roll

The ± 26 the night adds to the margin.

Snag

The thing that goes wrong during a recruitment trip.

Split

Who takes what out of the fee.

Standing

Where you stand with somebody: loyalty plus the nights you have been through together. Not the same number as loyalty, and the one that decides whether they take what you ask — see a new craft.

Tier

How big a posting is, 1 to 4 on the open board and 5 for an operation. Decides the fee, the weeks, the people needed and how long you may case it.

Trade

What somebody is — one of sixteen ordinary trades, or one of the fourteen specialists. Worth +14 when the client asked for it.

Twist

The thing that goes wrong during a job, and the options it offers.

Upkeep

A crew member's weekly wages. Paid whether they work or not.

Verdict

Clean, Success, Messy, Botched or Disaster.

Vetting

Paying \$6K to find out whether a file is an informant.

